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DJIA 42573.73 ▼ 418.48 0.97% NASDAQ 19486.78 ▼ 1.2% STOXX 600 504.85 ▼ 0.5% 10-YR. TREAS. ▲ 18/32, yield 4.546% OIL \$70.99 ▲ \$0.39 GOLD \$2,606.10 ▼ \$12.30 EURO \$1.0408 YEN 156.85

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **U.S. stocks racked up** another blockbuster showing in 2024, but few investors expect such a torrid advance in the year to come. **A1**
- ◆ **A year-end selloff** in technology stocks rattled markets on Monday. The Nasdaq, Dow and S&P 500 declined 1.2%, 1% and 1.1%, respectively. The 10-year Treasury yield fell to 4.546%. **B10**
- ◆ **Nvidia closed** its acquisition of Israeli software startup Run:ai following months of regulatory scrutiny across the globe. **B4**
- ◆ **Investors plowed more** than \$1 trillion into U.S.-based exchange-traded funds in 2024, shattering the previous record that was set three years ago. **B1**
- ◆ **The U.K.'s antitrust** watchdog said it was considering whether IBM's planned \$6.4 billion takeover of HashiCorp would affect competition. **B4**
- ◆ **Pending homes sales** in the U.S. grew for the fourth straight month in November to return to the highest level since early 2023. **A2**
- ◆ **Credit spreads tightened** throughout 2024, ending the year at levels not seen since at least the mid-2000s and helping to fuel a surge in companies' debt issuance. **B1**
- ◆ **Residents and lawmakers** in Atlanta are pushing back against data-center construction that is growing faster there than in just about any other major city amid an artificial-intelligence race. **B1**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Donald Trump endorsed** House Speaker Mike Johnson for another term, as Johnson worked the phones to tamp down rumblings that Republicans should seek an alternative leader. **A4**
- ◆ **A federal appeals court** upheld a \$5 million civil judgment against Trump for sexually abusing writer E. Jean Carroll in the mid-1990s. **A4**
- ◆ **The Jeju Air flight's final** moments are at the heart of a South Korean investigation into one of the worst aviation disasters in years. **A1**
- ◆ **The Treasury Department** told lawmakers that a state-sponsored actor in China hacked its systems. **A4**
- ◆ **Syria's new rulers** elevated a woman to run the country's central bank, as the U.S. and other Western governments watch how the Islamist rebels treat women. **A5**
- ◆ **The country's inexperienced** leaders are trying to figure out how to revive an economy decimated by sanctions and years of conflict. **A5**
- ◆ **The U.S. grew by 2.6** million people in 2024, and the U.S. population on New Year's Day will be 341 million, according to U.S. Census Bureau estimates. **A4**
- ◆ **An unprecedented** explosion of conflicts has carved a trail of death and destruction across Africa, yet the surge in fighting has gone largely unnoticed globally. **A7**
- ◆ **Died: Linda Lavin**, 87, star of TV sitcom 'Alice.' **A4**

NOTICE TO READERS

WSJ.com and WSJ mobile apps will publish on New Year's Day. The Wall Street Journal print edition won't be published on Wednesday.

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Stocks Set for Best 2 Years Since '90s

Interest-rate levels create doubts that market can maintain sizzling pace of 2024

By KAREN LANGLEY

U.S. stocks roared to another blockbuster showing in 2024. Few expect such a torrid advance in the year to come. The S&P 500 has climbed 24%, notching 57 record closes as the economy remained healthy, inflation ticked lower and an AI-fueled rally in big tech stocks powered on. Even with a stumble in the last few

trading days, the broad U.S. stock index is on pace for its best consecutive years since 1997 and 1998, according to Dow Jones Market Data, during the lead-up to the bursting of the dot-com bubble.

The rally has created millionaires and turned professional investors increasingly bullish: In December, the Bank of America Global Fund Manager Survey found record enthusiasm for U.S. stocks, as measured by the net share of respondents favoring the group. The payoffs haven't been limited to the equity market: Gold is on pace for its best year since 2010, while bit-

coin more than doubled, vaulting above \$100,000 for the first time before slipping below that mark.

Many investors anticipate that a resilient U.S. economy and a Federal Reserve that has switched to cutting interest rates—even if not as deeply as some had hoped—will allow stocks to push higher. But they caution against thinking that the rapid pace of gains in the past two years will repeat

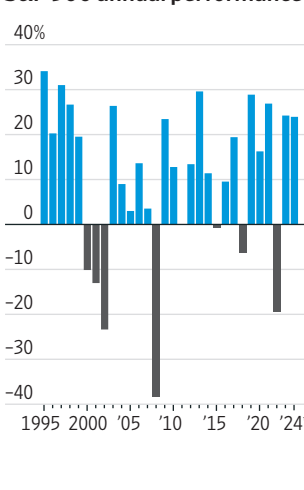
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- ◆ **ETFs get record \$1 trillion** 2024 inflow..... **B1**
- ◆ **Dow industrials, S&P 500 and Nasdaq fall**..... **B10**

S&P 500 performance this year



S&P 500 annual performance



Times Square Gets Ready to Ring In 2025



PARTY PREPS: Workers do a test run Monday, ahead of the famed ball drop in New York City on New Year's Eve. Hundreds of thousands of people are expected to attend, and more than a ton of confetti will rain down on the celebration.

UnitedHealth's Army of Doctors Helped It Boost Medicare Payments

Biggest Medicare Advantage insurer gave physicians checklists of potential diagnoses

Like most doctors, Nicholas Jones prefers to diagnose patients after examining them. When he worked for UnitedHealth

By Christopher Weaver, Anna Wilde Mathews and Tom McGinty

Group, though, the company frequently prepared him a checklist of potential diagnoses before he ever laid eyes on them.

UnitedHealth only did that with the Eugene, Ore., family physician's Medicare Advantage recipients, he said, and its software wouldn't let him move on to his next patient until he weighed in on each diagnosis.

The diagnoses were often irrelevant or wrong, Jones said. UnitedHealth sometimes suggested a hormonal condition, secondary hyperaldosteronism, that was so obscure Jones had to turn to Google for help. "I needed to look it up," he said.

The government's Medicare Advantage system, which uses private insurers to provide health benefits to seniors and disabled people, pays the companies based on how sick patients are, to cover the higher costs of sicker patients. Medicare calculates sickness scores from information supplied by doctors and submitted by the insurers. In the case of UnitedHealth, many of those doctors

work directly for UnitedHealth.

More diagnoses make for higher scores—and larger payments. A Wall Street Journal analysis found sickness scores increased when patients moved from traditional Medicare to Medicare Advantage, leading to billions of dollars in extra government payments to insurers.

Patients examined by doctors working for UnitedHealth, an industry pioneer in directly employing large numbers of physicians, had some of the biggest increases in sickness scores after moving

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- ◆ **Crisis-control test for CEO**..... **B1**

It's Peak Season For Chronic Party Crashers

An elite squad of interlopers have turned showing up uninvited into an art form

By JULIA MUNSLow AND LAURA MA

Paul Gee was searching for a holiday party in a New Jersey banquet hall when a staff member stopped him and asked if he knew where he was supposed to be.

"The company event?" Gee replied. Once the 31-year-old event host and entertainer found the right room, he scoped the scene, then beelined for the DJ. "Hey bro, let me see that real quick," said Gee, reaching for the mic. "Oh yeah, get it, c'mon!" Gee

shouted to the crowd. But Gee wasn't booked to host the event—he was just crashing the party.

It's high season for people like Gee, part of an elite group of gate-crashers who have turned showing up uninvited into an art form.

The basic playbook is the same: Dress the part, act confidently, conduct a little advance research, and don't cause a disturbance.

Like any good game of luck and chance, favored tactics vary. Some prefer to sneak onto the

Secret's out

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INSIDE



SPORTS

The NFL's race to the bottom is completely out of control. **A12**



BUSINESS & FINANCE

How a \$12.98 t-shirt at Walmart is made in America—at a profit. **B1**

Moments Before Crash: 'Should I Write a Will?'

SEOUL—At 8:57 a.m. on Sunday, the control tower at South Korea's Muan International Airport issued an alert to a Jeju Air flight approaching: "Caution: Bird Activity."

By Timothy W. Martin, Dasl Yoon, Soobin Kim and Benjamin Katz

The alert wasn't unusual at the airport, which is surrounded by several bird habitats that are home to various types of ducks and geese. But two minutes later, a call for help came from the cockpit: "Mayday, mayday, mayday, bird strike, bird strike, going around," one of the pilots said, according to South Korea's Transport Ministry.

About six minutes after the tower's warning, the plane crashed down without its landing gear deployed and smashed into a barrier at the

end of the airport's only runway, bursting into flames. Of the 181 passengers and crew on board, just two survived. Both were flight attendants seated at the back of the Boeing 737-800 jet.

The Jeju Air flight's final chaotic moments now sit at the heart of a South Korean investigation into one of the deadliest aviation disasters in years.

The U.S. National Transportation Safety Board, Boeing and the U.S. Federal Aviation Administration will assist in the probe—which could take months, if not longer—to determine the cause. Investigators retrieved the aircraft's black boxes but, with one partially damaged, the decoding process could take months, South Korea's Transport Ministry said.

On Monday, South Korea's acting President Choi Sang-yeon said the plane was "a tragedy." *Please turn to page A6*